THE LANTERN AT LOW TIDE

A short story written for Kenni

The old harbor bell had not rung in years. It stood at the end of the pier, green with salt, while the tide drew a silver seam around its stone.

Mara came there each evening with a lantern. Her grandfather had taught her to light it before the fog arrived. A small light is still a direction, he used to say.

One autumn night the fog rolled in early. From beyond the breakwater came three soft knocks: wood against wood. Then a voice called, too far away to make out.

Mara lifted the lantern high. The fog swallowed its glow, but she kept it there. A moment later, the harbor bell moved. Once. Twice. On the third note, a little fishing boat emerged from the gray, turning toward shore.

Its sailor stepped onto the pier and thanked her. Mara looked at the bell, still and quiet again. She understood then: the light had not made the fog disappear. It had only shown someone where to come home.

THE END

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